



How daredevil sees?

Ever wondered how Daredevil climbs buildings and fights bad guys without his eyesight? This video might give you some insight <http://dgit.in/daredevilsees>



WakeAndBake

what happens when 3 college students decide to start a startup called WakeAndBake? Find out: <http://dgit.in/1H3rXOh>

Budget laptops



review and to give our readers a great overall view of how good or bad Dell laptops compare to the competition. However, despite repeated attempts and waiting for over a month, we failed to get any Dell laptop. We still haven't received a unit at the time of going to print. Nevertheless, though, dear reader, we are on course to reviewing the machines that we couldn't in the next issue. So stay tuned for that. For now, let's see how these six budget laptops stack up against each other.

TWO ACERS

None of the laptops tested in this test are bad or not recommendable, and that's true even for the two Acer laptops which hit all the right check marks but didn't do much to separate itself from the pack. The Acer Aspire range continued to impress us with their E5 range of laptops, and we got two promising candidates from their stables. The fact that surprised us most about these two machines is that right out of the box, where

HOW WE TESTED

Initial setup: We tested these budget consumer laptops much like any other laptop we benchmark. All laptops to be tested are first examined and everything about them is catalogued, including bundled software, accessories, etc. We then completely wipe all data on the laptops and install a copy of the Windows 8.1 Enterprise Edition. Drivers and essential software are installed from the manufacturer's website before running Windows update. This is done to ensure that the laptops don't have any bloatware or trivial apps, only essential drivers that will help the device's hardware to run at optimum performance without any software bottlenecks. Finally, the devices are set to run in performance mode in the BIOS as well as in the power options. All performance inhibitors are turned off, as much as possible – stuff like hard drive idling to sleep, screen switching off, screen dimming on battery mode, etc. After this, the laptops are ready to go into the grinder of our performance benchmarks.

Performance tests: We conduct a whole series of tests on the devices to measure the impact of every aspect of the system on overall performance – tests that stress the laptop's CPU, RAM, GPU, hard drive, screen, thermals, battery, and more. These tests include industry standard benchmarks including (and not limited to) Futuremark's PCMark 8 and 3D Mark, MAXON Cinebench, and others. We use PCMark 8's Creative test suite to evaluate battery life of each laptop, as well. Results are carefully catalogued.

Screen brightness and contrast ratio is measured using the DataColor Spyder 4 Elite test unit – a color calibrator. It's essential to calibrate all laptop displays before objectively testing them, and we do just that. In dark rooms with little or no ambient light, the laptops are tested with Datacolor Spyder Studio. Brightness and contrast is tested at different luminance level, and an average of multiple readings is taken as the final score. We also test the screen's gradient through DisplayMate and Lagom.nl.

A series of subjective testing is also conducted that scores aspects such as a laptop's keyboard, touchpad, palmrest, screen readability, onboard speakers, look and feel, watching movies, playing games (if the laptop is meant for gaming), among others. These tests help complete the gamut of objective benchmarks with real-world test scenarios, allowing us to take a fairly homogeneous look at the laptop's overall performance.

The final performance score is arrived at which includes the weighted sum of all the scores

catalogued. Weights are assigned based on the perceived importance of the components. For example, since gaming doesn't really matter or is all that important on a business laptop, gaming benchmarks and scores from them are of lesser importance here than they would be on a home entertainment or gaming laptop. Stuff like battery life, screen brightness, CPU performance will be of significantly greater importance in a business setup.

Features score: The features present in each laptop are tabulated and given weighted scores depending on perceived importance. For example, dedicated multimedia keys and volume keys are given more weightage than those that are shared with Fn keys. An important note on features, we don't rate CPU, GPU, RAM characteristics any weight here, because we feel those characteristics already surface in the performance part of our testing. Example - Whether a laptop has a dual-core or quad-core laptop doesn't get lesser or higher points because both of these laptop's performances take those aspect into account. Features that directly impact performance are not counted or scored here.

Design and Usability: The scores for this parameter are largely subjective as they indicate our experience with the device. Items such as quality of the keyboard, responsiveness of the touch-screen, etc. are weighed and scored.

Final score: The final score that we arrive at is the sum of the performance, features and design scores with a 30%, 20% and 20% weightage, respectively. This is not a fixed weightage, and depending on the category of laptops we're testing, these weightages can be different.

A note on winners: The Best Buy laptop is awarded to the device with the best price to performance ratio based on a pre-determined formula. This is the ideal, value for money product in the test. The Best Performer award is awarded to the device with the highest overall performance score. The Editor's Pick award is awarded to the device that the reviewer feels is the best product that offers something extra or unique that none of the other laptops have. The Editor's Pick is an entirely subjective award, the decision for which is based on the reviewer's experience while testing the products. For this test, we withheld from announcing this award because there wasn't anything special in any of the laptops that didn't win Best Buy or Best Performer.